



ears swivel to detect prey



large eyes adapted for night vision

Sugar glider

Petaurus breviceps

The most widespread of all glider species, this highly social marsupial's most striking characteristic is its method of locomotion. The sugar glider launches itself from one tree and coasts to the next in a lengthy, controlled glide, courtesy of two furry winglike membranes. Just before it reaches its target, it swoops upward to land, clinging to the bark with strong claws. Sugar gliders rarely venture to the ground.

The importance of scent

Smell is a complex communication tool for these nocturnal possums. Dominant males use the scent glands on their foreheads, throats, chests, and tail region to mark territory—defended aggressively against intruders—as well as members of their colony. Up to seven adults and the season's young sleep together in leaf-lined tree hollows by day, partly for warmth. In cold or wet weather or times of drought, sugar gliders can enter a daily semihibernative state called torpor, lasting for up to 13 hours, to conserve energy.



furry membrane stretched wide when gliding

The sugar glider's **scientific name** means **short-headed rope dancer**



◁ HITCHING A RIDE

Young sugar gliders, called joeys, frequently cling to their mother's back as she goes in search of food.

△ LICKING SAP

Sugar gliders use large incisors to chisel into tree bark, exposing the sap that makes up a large part of their diet.



long rudderlike tail helps control direction of glide